

There is an urgent need to relook at its terms of reference," says Barun Mitra, director of the Liberty Institute. Environmentalists say the IPCC is simply not doing enough damage control. "Instead of issuing individual statements, the IPCC needs to come clean by putting together a clear unambiguous statement, stating that they are looking at the entire process of the report. We need to

ciers are in trouble and this mistake should not be used by climate sceptics and naysayers to say otherwise." True, many of the Himalayan glaciers are under retreat and there is a need to study the phenomenon in depth. The threat remains.

Pachauri, 'Patchy' to his friends, has the hirsute hallmarks of a scientist, a wispy carbon black comb over, though the white streak parting his

builder of reputation. He jokes about leaving behind a high carbon footprint because of his frequent flyer status but in two decades, TERI has been transformed from a wing of the Tata Group (which set it up 36 years ago) into an independent global think tank which has pioneered research in energy and environment and is globally sought for its expertise.

As its high profile director-general, Pachauri has attracted considerable international attention, now, it seems, for all the wrong reasons. "It's unfortunate," Pachauri laments. "Climate sceptics are looking for anything to demolish the science of climate change," he says, comparing them to the tobacco lobby which opposed the findings linking tobacco consumption with cancer. "I know a lot of climate sceptics are after my blood (his resignation) and I am in no mood to oblige them."

The fact that man-made global warming is a threat has been widely accepted or else over 190 nations would not sit down for talks at the UN Convention on Climate Change at Copenhagen. The jury is out on how intense the threat is and whether they directly affect weather patterns. The 'warmists' believe climate change is being caused entirely by man-made factors and the 'sceptics' believe otherwise. The jury is still out on the subject. "We can't get certainty from a 24-hour weather forecast, how do you expect it for climate forecast?" laments Nitin Desai, former member of the Commonwealth group on climate change. "Both sides of the debate are working with very few data points, leaving the lay people at loose ends," says Desai, calling for more research.

What is needed is a thorough review of IPCC procedures to bolster its flagging credibility. Pachauri can begin with that. He is likely to face even more heat as the tempo to not only bash the IPCC but his own credentials will increase. He needs to constantly come out with a credible defence. For if he can't face the heat, he may well have to stay out of the IPCC kitchen. ■

THOUGH THE IPCC HAS DEFENDED ITS CLAIMS, A THOROUGH REVIEW OF ITS PROCEDURES IS REQUIRED SO THAT ITS CREDIBILITY CAN BE RESTORED.



AP PHOTO

PACHAURI PRESENTING THE IPCC'S FOURTH ASSESSMENT REPORT TO UN SECRETARY-GENERAL BAN KI-MOON (SECOND FROM RIGHT) IN 2007

know it from them, and not from investigative journalists, otherwise the climate change debate will get diverted," says Kartikeya Sarabhai, founder and director, Centre for Environment Education (CEE). Others advise caution. "Climate change is a reality," emphasises Sunita Narain of the Centre for Science and Environment. "It is very clear the gla-

black beard like a Himalayan rivulet gives him the air of a vizier from an Arabian nights tale than a climate change guru. Yet, his getting the prized chair of the IPCC two times in a row (he was re-elected in 2007) is a feat the incredible networker has managed to pull off. Even his worst critics concede the jetsetting Pachauri's ability as an institution